

DELHI | Price Watch

How long can it take to fix a new Wholesale Price Index (WPI), the most-watched measure of inflation? Two to four years at the most. But for the government, it took nearly a decade since the last revision in April 2000 and a series of reports by experts to zero in on the list of commodities to be included in the new index. The new

WPI which will be released on a monthly basis from November 14 takes into account price movements of more than 850 articles against the 435 in the current index and is likely to be more accurate. Cut flowers, cellphones, laptops and digital cameras have made their way in the new index in tune with changing consumption patterns.

by Nivedita Mukherjee



KOLKATA | Power of Babel

**WEST BENGAL
WILL NOW SEE
MINORITY
GROUPS BEING
CLASSIFIED ON
THE BASIS OF
LANGUAGE AND
NOT RELIGION.**

In an unprecedented move to woo Maoland, the state Government will soon come out with a notification on a set of languages that will define minority status instead of religion as mentioned in the 1966 law. The languages are Urdu, Hindi, Nepali, Oriya, Telugu and, significantly, Santhali. The Government says once the law comes into effect, more and more people will get educational jobs, making way for educational institutions for these sections. These sops would obviously see more jobs for Santhalis, at least as teachers in these proposed schools.

by Abhijit Dasgupta

KERALA | Water War

Union Minister for Environment and Forests Jairam Ramesh's permission to Kerala to conduct a preliminary survey for constructing a dam at Mullaperiyar on the Kerala-Tamil Nadu border has created friction between the two states. While Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi accused Kerala of highhandedness in deciding to build the dam which he said would deny water to Tamil Nadu, AIADMK supremo J. Jayalalithaa compared the move to China's to build a dam across the Brahmaputra. Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan said, "It's the competitive politics of Jayalalithaa and Karunanidhi which has made them turn blind to the safety risk the old dam poses to Kerala."

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

WITH CATCHY SLOGANS AND PAINTINGS, CITY WALLS WILL SOON DON A NEW LOOK.

BANGALORE | The Eyes Have It

If you want a view of a scenic beach spot, lush with coconut trees, head to the underpass on Bellary Road. Or if you want to see the Hampi ruins or the temples of Pattadakal, take a look at some of the civic walls in Bangalore. From inviting murals to catchy slogans, the corporation plans to rid the city of visual pollution. Initiated by Corporation Commissioner Bharat Lal Meena, the drive will employ nearly 200 commercial artists to paint walls across the city. The wall art is not just a welcome addition to India's Silicon Valley; the assignment has also helped painters who had lost their jobs to digital technology. "Almost all important landmarks of the state covering history, heritage monuments, wildlife, tourism and even general landmarks would be featured here," says Meena. His programme truly stands by the slogan of the state Tourism Department—"one state, many worlds".

by Stephen David

